

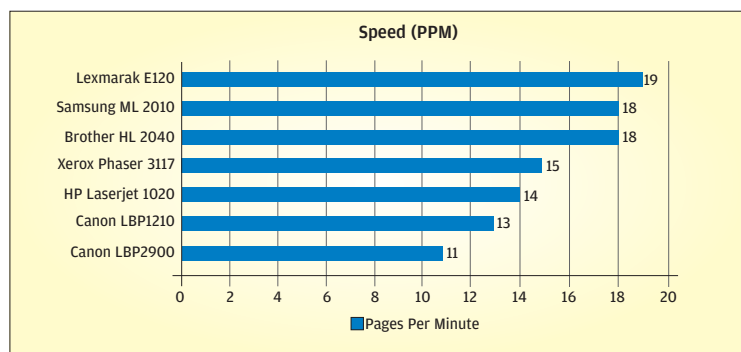
How We Tested

All the printers were connected via USB to a PC with an Intel Pentium 3.2 GHz CPU, 512 MB of DDR2 memory, and a 120 GB Seagate Barracuda 7200 rpm hard drive running a fresh install of Windows XP SP2. We formatted and reinstalled Windows for every printer to make sure none of the previous printer's software or drivers would cause any conflicts. We used 75 g/sm JK Paper for the text prints, and Berga 100 g/sm paper for the photo prints.

All the tests were carried out in both Normal and Best modes. We logged the time

each printer took to print the first page, and also calculated how many pages a printer could print in a minute. Quality, being a more subjective test, was conducted by multiple reviewers to minimise errors in judgement. All the prints were compared to each other, and all the printers had maintenance schedules run prior to printing, using the bundled software maintenance kit.

This time round, we also awarded points for type of warranty, prices of consumables, and availability of support and service as well as consumables across the country.



years. All these companies have on-site warranties. HP is the only company that provides a lifetime, unit-replacement warranty.

Start Your Toners

Moving on to the test, we had one printer each from Brother, Samsung, Xerox, HP, and Lexmark, and two printers from Canon. On the technical front, all these printers were evenly matched and all fell below the Rs 10,000 mark we set for the SoHo environment.

Design

There are two aspects to the designing of a product— aesthetics and function. A perfect balance of these two parameters is essential for the product to look good without hampering day-to-day usability. Canon's LBP-2900 is the smartest-looking printer—compact, curved edges, yet functional in all possible ways. The single-piece paper tray is fitted flush with the body.

HP's 1020, Samsung's ML-2010, Xerox's Phaser 3117, and Lexmark's E120 looked almost identical. All these have a vertical profile design and hence take up less desk space. The input paper trays are completely

retractable and fold back into the body; however, the output trays are a little flimsy.

Brother's HL-2040 and Canon's LBP-1210 have a wider profile and require more desk space. While the Brother has a paper cassette that fits snugly with the body, the paper cassette on the Canon LBP-1210 juts out occupying additional space.

Overall, Canon's LBP-2900 takes the "best-looking printer" crown, closely followed by the HP 1020 and Lexmark E120.

How To Buy

- ❑ First figure your monthly print run—if it's above 3,000 pages, you're looking at the wrong segment. Consider a high duty-cycle printer instead.
- ❑ If you're looking to add a printer to a network, and share it amongst a group, look for a printer with an Ethernet port. This will save electricity, as it does not need a print server PC to be always on.
- ❑ Check out which brand has the nearest service centre. If you can get hold of their number, call them up and ask them their turnaround time.
- ❑ Call up your regular stationery guy and figure out what brand of consumables he generally stocks. Alternatively, call the toll-free numbers (we have collated them for you) of all manufacturers and see how

much time will it take for them to provide you any consumable.

- ❑ Before buying a printer, make sure you get a demonstration, and insist on being shown the manageability provided by the accompanying software. Manageability refers to general servicing such as cleaning of toner, remote management of printer, and other features.

	Toll-Free For Service	Toll-Free For Consumables
Brother	NA	NA
HP	1800-4257737	1800-4254999
Canon	1800-3453366	1800-3453366
Lexmark	1800-224477	1800-224477
Samsung	1800-110011	3030-8282
Xerox	1800-4254525	1800-1801225
Epson	1800-4250011	1800-4250011